realized that I needed to change the culture of bureaucracy to make it *life-sensitive* versus *file-sensitive*, which had been the case since our Independence. I proactively took several initiatives to form small groups of senior officers, assign them common goals to work on and spent a lot of time with them. Eventually, the officers began to understand what my expectations were from them and began to respond to my calls much more efficiently as a unit. So, when the pandemic struck, I was confident in the ability of my government and the officers to rise to the challenge before us. Now let me give you another example. Look at the way we have adopted digitization. Many nations struggled with getting COVID-19 relief monies to the final beneficiaries either due to political reasons or because their systems weren't equipped to connect the government to the beneficiaries. But thanks to our wholehearted adoption of direct benefit transfers, we were able to promptly and quickly credit funds into the accounts of our most vulnerable folks. To reiterate, I have never been one to feel pressure. However, I do firmly believe in preparation and it is this very preparation that helped us face the crisis.'

I asked further, 'You are the first Indian prime minister to face the Herculean challenge of such a once-in-a-lifetime pandemic. How did you retain your optimism in India and what motivated you during those difficult days?'

He replied naturally, without even thinking about the answer, 'As you may know, only recently I completed two decades of experience in public service. Twenty years ago, my public career began with a crisis in the form of an earthquake in Kutch. So, leading through crises is certainly not new for me. When I was in school, floods in Tapi and Narmada rivers due to overflowing were rather common. There were no dams built on these rivers then. Their flooding used to become big news. I have this image in my mind, perhaps something I may have seen in the media then of Morarji Desai, who was then a Member of Parliament, sitting in a rail engine to go to Surat to visit flood-affected areas. Influenced by actions of a senior leader like him, my friends and I set up a stall in the *shravan mahina mela* organized in our village where we sold some local food products. At the end of the mela, we had collected about ₹25–30 profit as a group which we then donated towards flood-relief measures. Years later, during the unfortunate Morbi Dam burst, where thousands of people had lost their lives, I volunteered to help with rehabilitation. I recollect staying amidst the